FOURTH SIGNAL × UNILEVER

Sales Strategy Analysis
Business User Guide

A practical framework for interpreting annual-report intelligence, assessing account opportunities, developing discovery hypotheses, and converting research into an evidence-led sales strategy.

Strategic workflow

Public disclosure → business issue hypothesis → stakeholder hypothesis → discovery → validation → value assessment → targeted solution discussion → defined next step

Prepared as a companion to the Fourth Signal × Unilever sales-strategy Python and Jupyter Notebook project.

Important: The analysis identifies potential areas for investigation. It does not establish Unilever's current technology architecture, internal processes, procurement status, or use of Fourth Signal solutions.

1. Executive Purpose

The purpose of this project is to establish a repeatable, evidence-led approach to account research for Fourth Signal. The Unilever Annual Report and Accounts 2024 is used as the working example.

The methodology converts publicly disclosed financial, treasury, risk and transformation information into a structured set of potential business issues. These issues are then mapped to potential stakeholders, discovery questions and appropriate sales motions.

> **The intended outcome is not a prediction of customer requirements.** The intended outcome is a better-informed commercial conversation in which publicly available evidence is used to test relevant hypotheses.

2. Project Components

Component	Business purpose	Recommended use
Python analysis script	Automates extraction, signal detection, scoring and output generation.	Use as the repeatable analytical engine for new accounts and new reports.
Jupyter Notebook	Provides an interactive and transparent view of the analysis.	Use for account reviews, hypothesis development, demonstrations and further analysis.
Opportunity CSV	Provides a structured view of identified sales signals.	Use as an account-prioritisation and working-analysis file.
Account strategy Markdown	Summarises the account thesis and recommended sales motion.	Use as an internal account-planning brief.
Business Guide PDF	Explains how to interpret and operationalise the analysis.	Use as the reference document for applying the methodology.

3. Recommended Approach to the Jupyter Notebook

The Jupyter Notebook should be treated as the primary analytical interface for business users. Users do not need to understand the underlying Python implementation before using the outputs.

1. Execute the notebook sequentially from the first analytical cell.

2. Review the ranked opportunity table and identify the highest-priority signals for further investigation.

3. Review the cited annual-report pages for each selected signal.

4. Separate disclosed facts from analytical interpretation and commercial hypotheses.

5. Review the suggested stakeholder groups and discovery questions.

6. Select a limited number of hypotheses for account engagement rather than presenting the entire analysis to a prospect.

4. Interpreting the Opportunity Analysis

Analysis field	Business interpretation
Signal	A material theme identified in the company's public disclosures that may warrant further commercial investigation.
Score	A transparent heuristic used to prioritise research. It is not a measure of customer propensity, revenue potential or probability of purchase.

Analysis field	Business interpretation
Evidence pages	The annual-report locations that support the underlying observation and should be reviewed before using the point externally.
Buyer roles	Potential stakeholder groups associated with the issue. Actual ownership should be established through discovery.
Discovery question	A question designed to test whether the inferred business issue exists and is material.
Sales motion	A suggested engagement format, such as a diagnostic, workshop or process assessment, that can validate the issue.

5. Unilever Treasury and Finance Signals

Foreign-exchange exposure and hedging

Commercial relevance: The report provides evidence of foreign-exchange derivatives and hedging activity. This can support an investigation into the efficiency, integration and control of the FX lifecycle.

Discovery: How are FX exposures captured, approved, hedged, accounted for and reported, and where does the process remain manual or fragmented?

Interest-rate risk and debt management

Commercial relevance: The report describes fixed and floating debt and the use of interest-rate swaps. This creates a potential entry point into debt and interest-rate risk processes.

Discovery: How are debt positions, market rates, derivatives and hedge-accounting information connected across the treasury process?

Counterparty credit risk and controls

Commercial relevance: The report describes group-wide counterparty limits, monitoring, netting and collateral arrangements.

Discovery: How are counterparty exposure, limits, collateral and exceptions consolidated and monitored across the organisation?

Cash visibility and liquidity

Commercial relevance: The report identifies cash held across subsidiaries and notes restrictions that can affect availability.

Discovery: How does Group Treasury obtain a consolidated and timely view of cash, liquidity and potentially restricted or trapped balances?

Global treasury operating complexity

Commercial relevance: The multinational operating environment provides a basis for investigating the balance between global standardisation and local treasury requirements.

Discovery: Which treasury processes are globally standardised and which remain dependent on local systems, processes or manual intervention?

Technology, productivity and transformation

Commercial relevance: The wider report provides a basis for examining how finance technology, automation and productivity initiatives affect treasury processes.

Discovery: Which treasury and finance activities offer the greatest opportunity for automation, improved visibility or stronger controls?

Working capital and cash conversion

Commercial relevance: The company's focus on cash generation and working capital can provide an executive-level context for treasury visibility and process efficiency.

Discovery: Which treasury or finance processes currently constrain cash visibility, liquidity management or the speed of cash conversion?

6. From Research to Commercial Engagement

The analysis should be used to improve the quality and specificity of account engagement. The recommended progression is from evidence to validation rather than from evidence directly to a product pitch.

Stage	Objective	Expected output
Evidence	Establish what the company has publicly disclosed.	Verified source statement and page reference.
Hypothesis	Translate the disclosure into a potential operational, control or technology issue.	Business issue hypothesis.
Stakeholder mapping	Identify likely process owners and influencers.	Initial stakeholder map.
Discovery	Determine whether the issue exists and assess materiality.	Validated or rejected hypothesis.
Diagnostic / workshop	Examine the relevant process in sufficient detail.	Current-state understanding and pain points.
Value assessment	Quantify potential impact in relevant business terms.	Value case / improvement baseline.
Pilot / next step	Define a contained and measurable engagement.	Agreed scope, outcomes and commercial pathway.

Commercial principle: Public disclosure should establish relevance, not be presented as proof of an internal customer problem. The customer conversation establishes the facts required for a credible opportunity.

7. Validation Requirements

Before using any hypothesis as the basis for a targeted account approach, validate the areas that cannot be established from the annual report.

• SAP and treasury technology footprint relevant to the process under discussion.

• Current systems supporting FX, debt, cash, risk and hedge-accounting activities.

• Degree of process standardisation across group, regional and local treasury operations.

• Use of spreadsheets, manual reconciliation or point-to-point interfaces.

• Current transformation programmes or finance/treasury technology initiatives.

• Ownership of the process and the relevant decision-making structure.

• Operational impact expressed through time, control effort, risk, reporting effort, visibility or working-capital outcomes.

8. Improving the Analytical Engine

The Python script is structured so that the methodology can be extended beyond the Unilever use case. The following enhancements would increase its value as a repeatable sales-enablement asset.

Enhancement	Business benefit
Expanded signal library	Broader coverage of treasury, liquidity, intercompany, trade finance, risk and finance-transformation themes.
Industry-specific terminology	Improved signal detection for FMCG, manufacturing, financial services and other target sectors.

Enhancement	Business benefit
Company-specific dictionaries	Higher precision for recurring terminology, systems and organisational language.
Historical report comparison	Identification of recurring, increasing or newly disclosed issues across reporting periods.
Structured stakeholder data	More consistent account planning and engagement preparation.
CRM integration	Potential transition from research output to an operational account-development workflow.

9. Recommended 90-Day Account Development Framework

Period	Primary activity	Output
Days 1–10	Review and validate the highest-value annual-report signals.	Account thesis and evidence base.
Days 11–20	Develop stakeholder and technology hypotheses.	Stakeholder and architecture map.
Days 21–30	Develop evidence-led engagement themes.	Targeted outreach propositions.
Days 31–45	Conduct discovery and test the identified hypotheses.	Validated business issues.
Days 46–60	Conduct a focused diagnostic or workshop where appropriate.	Current-state process assessment.
Days 61–75	Quantify potential business impact and define a candidate use case.	Value case and pilot hypothesis.
Days 76–90	Agree scope, success measures and commercial next steps.	Defined pilot, proposal or subsequent engagement.

10. Account-Engagement Checklist

■ The relevant annual-report disclosure has been reviewed and can be accurately summarised.

■ The source page has been recorded for internal verification.

■ Facts, interpretations and commercial hypotheses have been clearly separated.

■ A primary stakeholder hypothesis and an alternative stakeholder have been identified.

■ A focused discovery question has been prepared.

■ The potential Fourth Signal relevance can be explained without assuming an existing technology environment.

■ A measurable next step has been identified.

■ Any customer-facing statement can be supported by evidence or clearly presented as a question.

11. Business Use of the Framework

The long-term value of the project is the methodology rather than the individual Unilever analysis. The same framework can be applied to additional target accounts by replacing the source report, maintaining the signal library, and adapting the hypotheses to the company's industry, operating model and disclosed priorities.

Recommended operating model: use the annual report to establish account relevance, use the analytical engine to structure the research, use external account intelligence to refine stakeholder hypotheses, and use customer discovery to validate the commercial case.

12. Final Operating Principle

The objective is not to demonstrate how much research has been completed. The objective is to enter the account with a small number of well-supported hypotheses that create relevant business conversations.

Evidence should create relevance. Discovery should establish the problem. Quantification should establish value. A defined next step should establish the opportunity.

This document should be read together with the Python script, Jupyter Notebook, README, opportunity CSV and account-strategy output.